

Mapping With Melanin™ — Business Placeholder Image System

PASTE-READY REPLIT INSTRUCTIONS

Priority: HIGH — Must be implemented before any new businesses are surfaced to users

Applies to: All businesses with `listing_status = live_unclaimed` or `staged` that do NOT have an owner-uploaded photo

The Problem

When businesses are bulk-seeded (from the founder's verified list, cultural guides, or community submissions), they do not have owner-uploaded photos. The system needs a placeholder image strategy that is:

1. **Culturally respectful** — NEVER assign stereotypical images based on cuisine, ownership ethnicity, or neighborhood
 2. **Premium and intentional** — The placeholder should feel designed, not broken
 3. **Incentivizing** — It should make business owners WANT to claim their page and upload their own photo
 4. **Consistent** — Every unclaimed business gets the same treatment regardless of category or ownership
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The Solution: Branded Placeholder Card + Category Icon

What to Display (in order of visual hierarchy):

Plain Text

[Category Icon - centered]
(neutral, monochrome/gold)

— Business Name —

"Claim this business to add
your photo & story"



Design Specifications:

Element	Specification
Background	MWM brand gradient (warm cream → soft gold) or solid warm neutral (#FAF7F2)
Category Icon	Centered, 48-64px, monochrome gold (#C8960C) or dark charcoal (#2D2D2D)
Business Name	Centered below icon, bold, 16-18px, dark charcoal
CTA Text	"Claim this business to add your photo & story" — 12px, muted gray
MWM Watermark	Bottom corner, very subtle, 8px opacity 30%
Border/Card	Soft rounded corners (12px), subtle shadow
Aspect Ratio	16:9 for list cards, 1:1 for map pin previews

Category Icon Mapping

Use NEUTRAL, non-stereotypical icons. These represent the SERVICE TYPE only — never the culture, cuisine origin, or ownership ethnicity.

Main Category	Icon	Description
Food & Drink	 (fork & knife)	Simple utensils — NOT a taco, NOT fried chicken, NOT chopsticks
Beauty & Personal Care	 (scissors)	Universal beauty symbol
Health & Wellness	 (heart)	Care/wellness heart
Shopping & Retail	 (shopping bag)	Neutral retail bag
Travel & Hospitality	 (suitcase)	Travel symbol

Arts, Culture & Entertainment	 (masks)	Performance/arts
Professional Services	 (briefcase)	Professional symbol
Home & Property Services	 (house)	Home symbol
Automotive & Transportation	 (car)	Vehicle symbol
Events & Celebrations	 (party)	Celebration symbol
Education & Learning	 (books)	Learning symbol
Children & Family	 (baby)	Family symbol
Community & Nonprofit	 (handshake)	Community symbol
Faith & Spirituality	 (dove)	Peace/spirit — NOT a cross, NOT a crescent, NOT a star
Media & Creative Services	 (clapperboard)	Creative/media
Sports & Recreation	 (ball)	Activity symbol
Pets & Animal Services	 (paw)	Animal care
Technology & Digital Services	 (laptop)	Tech symbol
Financial & Business Services	 (chart)	Finance symbol
Legal & Government Services	 (scales)	Justice/legal
Agriculture & Specialty Producers	 (seedling)	Growth/farming
Other Services	 (star)	General quality

IMPLEMENTATION NOTE: Use SVG icons, not emoji. The emoji above are for reference only. Use a clean icon library (Lucide, Heroicons, or custom SVG) in monochrome gold or charcoal. Icons should be simple line-art style, not filled/colored.

ABSOLUTE RULES — DO NOT VIOLATE

✗ NEVER DO:

1. **NEVER** assign a food image based on cuisine type (no tacos for Mexican restaurants, no jollof for Nigerian, no soul food plates for Black-owned)
2. **NEVER** assign a cultural image based on ownership ethnicity

3. **NEVER** use AI-generated placeholder photos of food, people, or storefronts
4. **NEVER** use stock photos of any kind
5. **NEVER** use the same generic photo for multiple businesses
6. **NEVER** pull images from Google, Yelp, or any third-party source without explicit owner permission
7. **NEVER** assign different placeholder styles based on ownership designation
8. **NEVER** use religious symbols as category icons for faith businesses (use the neutral dove)

ALWAYS DO:

1. **ALWAYS** use the same branded placeholder system for ALL unclaimed businesses regardless of category, ethnicity, or location
2. **ALWAYS** display the business name on the placeholder (this makes it feel intentional, not broken)
3. **ALWAYS** include the claim CTA — this drives business owner engagement
4. **ALWAYS** use the category icon that matches the business's Main Category (from Category Reference sheet)
5. **ALWAYS** make the placeholder look premium — this represents the MWM brand

When Photos DO Appear

Photos should ONLY appear on a business profile when:

Source	When It Shows
Owner uploads after claiming	Immediately upon approval
Community member submits a photo	After moderation review
Cultural ambassador posts content	After moderation review
Founder manually adds during tour	Immediately (admin privilege)

Photo moderation rules:

- No photos of people without their consent
- No photos that could identify a reporter (safety)

- Business exterior/interior photos are always safe
 - Food photos are safe when submitted by the person who visited
 - Owner-uploaded photos get priority placement over community photos
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Implementation Checklist

- ☐ Create SVG icon set for all 22 categories (monochrome, two sizes: 48px and 64px)
 - ☐ Build the placeholder card component (React Native for mobile, React for web)
 - ☐ Ensure placeholder renders at both 16:9 (list view) and 1:1 (map pin preview) aspect ratios
 - ☐ Add `has_owner_photo` boolean field to businesses table (default: false)
 - ☐ When `has_owner_photo = false`, render placeholder card instead of image
 - ☐ When business is claimed and owner uploads photo, set `has_owner_photo = true`
 - ☐ Placeholder card should be a reusable component: `<BusinessPlaceholder category={mainCategory} name={businessName} />`
 - ☐ Test that ALL 22 category icons render correctly
 - ☐ Verify no cultural stereotyping in any placeholder across all seeded businesses
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Verification Test

After implementation, Replit should provide screenshots showing:

1. A Food & Drink business placeholder (should show fork & knife, NOT food)
2. A Beauty business placeholder (should show scissors)
3. A Faith business placeholder (should show dove, NOT a cross)
4. A Health business placeholder (should show heart)
5. All should look identical in style, differing ONLY in the category icon and business name

The test passes when: A person looking at any placeholder cannot determine the ethnicity of the business owner or the cultural origin of the business from the placeholder image alone.

Why This Matters

The founder's vision: "When I first used Replit, they used an image of a taco for Hispanic. We need to be culturally sensitive."

MWM serves 91+ ownership designations across the entire diaspora. A placeholder system that assigns images based on assumptions is:

- Reductive (a Dominican salon is not the same as a Nigerian salon)
- Stereotyping (not all Black-owned restaurants serve soul food)
- Disrespectful (the business owner's story is THEIRS to tell)

The branded placeholder says: "We know you're here. We respect you. Your space is ready when you are."